Chapter 5.

A TRANSFORMATIONAL DECADE

Laying the Foundations of a Leading Power

In 2015, PM Narendra Modi publicly articulated India's quest to become a leading power one day. Some treated it as a statement of arrival when it was actually meant to be an expression of an aspiration. In the decade that has passed, it has also become clearer that this is now work in serious progress. While inaugurating the Bharat Mandapam in 2023, the same thinking was reiterated by the PM in a determination to emerge as the third-largest global economy. And a year before, in a departure from tradition, he made a public appeal to think and plan for an entire era, not just a term in office. This was characterized as *Amrit Kaal*, a quarter century with its goal as India's emergence as a developed nation.

Each of these assertions has a profound foreign-policy implication, especially because they are being voiced not merely as a broad ambition but with specific targets and goals for which India is now strategizing. The achievements of the last decade point to how steadily and systematically the foundations are being laid for a global footprint.

From his first day in office as the PM, Narendra Modi put his stamp on the nation's foreign policy. He demonstrated diplomatic imagination by inviting neighbouring leaders to his oath-taking ceremony in 2014, a step that orthodox thinking had not even contemplated. His US visit later that year served to bring on stage a new kind of public diplomacy. He infused greater energy into Indian endeavours, reaching out with an intensity and spread that was so different from his predecessors. In the time that has passed, PM Modi tabled fresh ideas and initiatives in various geographies and domains, ranging from energy and climate to counter-terrorism and connectivity. He has been active on key global issues, often directly shaping the outcomes.